on a piece of land opposite the Colaba Post Office owned by the Tata Trusts. The land was recovered from the government, which had requisitioned several such properties owned by the Tata Group during the Second World War, of which only a few have been returned. Earlier, an old cottage stood on the land that was dismantled after it was returned to the Tata Trusts. The house is in the same compound as Ashley House, a three-storeyed residential building belonging to the Tatas and constructed in 1940. The land will return to the Trusts after Ratan's time.

Halekai is the most elaborate of the four houses that Ratan has personally designed. The first house he had designed was at Jamshedpur, when he was training at TISCO. It has a unique style and is occupied currently by Tridibesh Mukherjee. The second home he designed was for his mother, on Peddar Road. The third one is a small beach house in Alibaug.

Halekai is a five-bedroom independent house made of steel and glass, with columns that are mostly concealed. It follows a style that Emmons and Jones made famous. From the outside, it has a contemporary multi-level look. Ratan's residence has been a subject of speculation for those who have not had the privilege to see it for themselves. Some have described it as one of the most luxurious houses in Mumbai. But it is anything but that.

The house is minimalistic and spartan. There is hardly anything in it that is imported. Its fittings can be found in most upper-middle-class Indian homes. The front door leads on the left to the drawing room that overlooks the lawn and the Arabian Sea. A large stone-coloured statue of a smiling Buddha head greets a visitor entering the uncluttered room. It is not easy to tell at first sight that it is made of plaster of Paris and would not have cost more than a couple of thousand rupees!

The drawing room has a plain leather sofa placed against the wall and a centre table with some stools and chairs around it, giving it the resemblance of the sitting room of a struggling entrepreneur. The only thing that has a semblance of being uncommon and majestic is a large painting of a tiger that hangs above the sofa, a Ratan favourite that he says he picked up in Paris. To the right of the drawing room is the dining space. It has a round marble-top table with six tulip-shaped plastic chairs around it—which look barely strong enough to take the weight of anyone who might weigh more than average, though Shireen says that it is from a well-known international brand. The table doubles up as Ratan's office desk and dining table. During